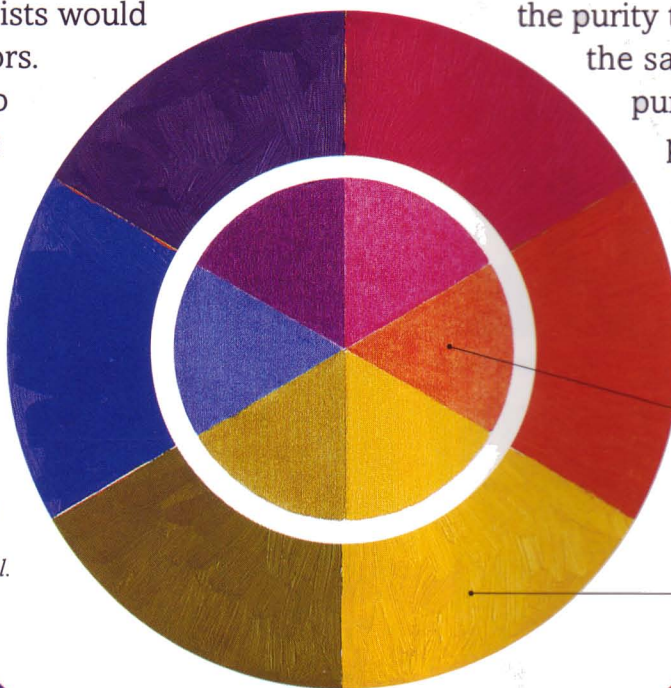


CHOOSING COLORS

MOST ARTISTS LEARN about color by discovering how it works in practice. Painting is a constant process of individual experimentation and discovery, and it is unlikely that any two artists would work with the same colors. It is, however, helpful to look at some of the basic theories of color in relation to oil painting.

Color wheel

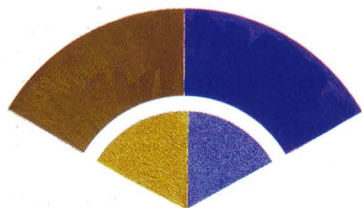
This color wheel shows the three primaries – red, yellow, and blue – and the three secondary colors in between that are made by mixing two of the primaries. The wheel also shows two main methods of mixing oil color; the paint has been mixed opaquely on the outside wheel, and transparently on the inside wheel.



Ideally, artists would need only the primary colors of red (magenta), yellow, and blue, plus white, to mix any color. In reality it can be difficult to find suitable pigments of the purity that allow, for instance, the same yellow to make a pure orange with red, and a pure green with blue. Use instead a limited palette of versatile colors.

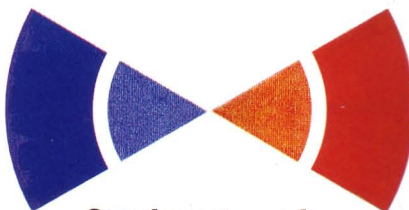
These colors have been painted very thinly, or transparently, over a white surface, which shows their true color, and not as they appear when squeezed out of a tube.

Opaque colors, with their rich, well-bodied appearance, conceal the surface on which they are painted. Transparent colors can be made to look opaque by adding white paint.



Adjacent colors

Adjacent colors have some similarity in hue (the actual color of an object or substance). Green contains blue in its mix, which gives these hues an automatic link. On a color wheel with a wider range of colors, adjacent colors are those that are positioned next to one another.



Complementary colors

Pairs of colors situated opposite each other on the color wheel give maximum contrast and enhance one another to appear brighter.

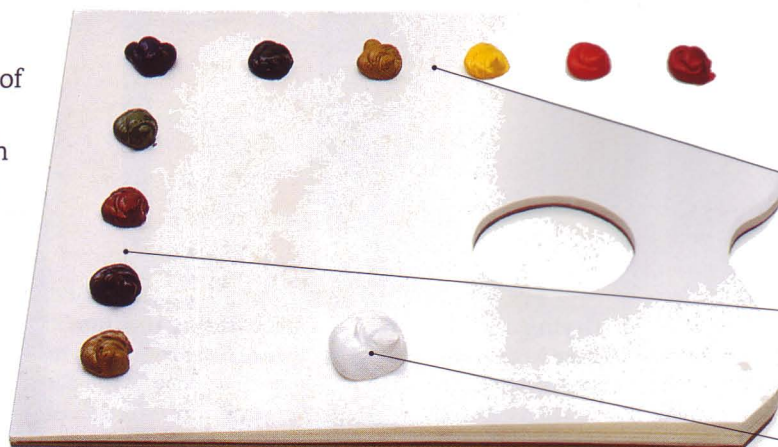


Warm and cool colors

Reds are usually thought of as warm, and blues cool. In fact, depending on their hue and context, colors can be warm or cool. Here one red (left) is cool and the other red warm. It is important to know this when mixing colors, as the cool red makes a better violet if mixed with blue.

Arranging your palette

When you choose a palette of colors, try to include both a warm and a cool color of each hue, or a versatile color such as Winsor Blue. There are no set rules for laying out your colors, but it makes sense to place adjacent colors next to one another and to keep white paint separate.



The top six colors are mainly primary colors, combining opaque and transparent paints, and placed in the order of the color spectrum.

The paints along the side include naturally opaque earth colors and more muted, low-key colors.

Keep white paint slightly separate as it will be used mainly for lightening other colors.